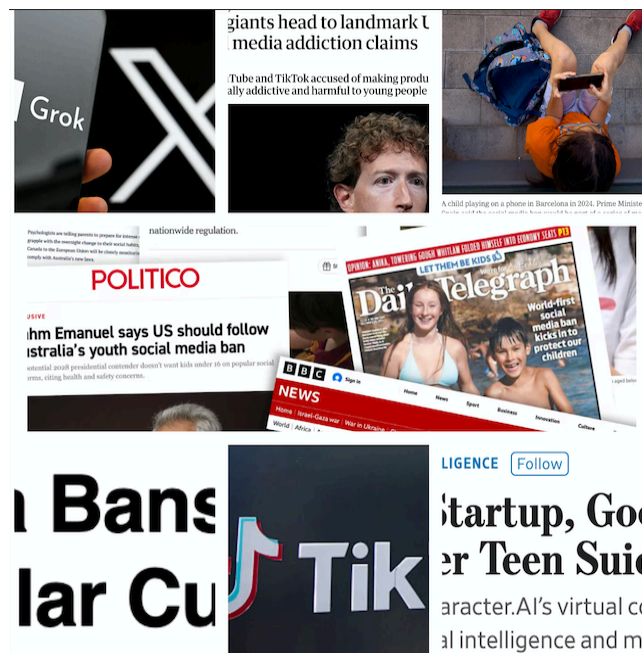




CURRENT ISSUES & EVENTS

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2026 • DISTRICT



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UNIVERSITY INTERSCHOLASTIC LEAGUE
CURRENT ISSUES & EVENTS CONTEST
DISTRICT • SPRING 2026

1. _____ attended oral arguments in the Supreme Court case which will determine if President Trump can fire Lisa Cook and called it “perhaps the most important legal case in the Fed’s 113-year history.” Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent called the decision a “mistake” saying it was politicizing the case.

A. Chuck Schumer	C. J. D. Vance
B. Jerome Powell	D. Gavin Newsom

2. The _____ took control of the western Darfur region after ousting the rival Sudanese army from el-Fasher. Since then, reports and videos have circulated of atrocities against civilians that the U.N. believes may constitute crimes against humanity.

A. Lord’s Resistance Army	C. Rapid Support Forces
B. Ansar ul Islam	D. Boko Haram

3. Residents in _____ scenic and mountainous north have been on edge after an unprecedented rise in bear attacks, many of which have resulted in deaths or serious injuries. As of the end of November, 235 bear attacks had killed 13 people in 2025, the highest figures in the country since records began in 2006.

A. Russia’s	C. Italy’s
B. Canada’s	D. Japan’s

4. A debate over whether a deadly strike by the U.S. on an alleged drug smuggling boat in September violated international law was ignited in January when news broke that the aircraft used in the operation had been _____.

A. painted to look like a civilian plane
B. piloted by the CIA and not the U.S. military
C. operating in international waters
D. flying over airspace reserved for domestic airports

5. TikTok finalized a deal to create a new entity, avoiding a ban in the U.S. due to national security concerns over ties between the Chinese government and the original owner, ____.
- A. Tencent
B. Baidu
C. ByteDance
D. Alibaba
6. In December, hundreds of works were damaged at the ____ when a pipe burst because of flooding. The flooding damaged at least 300 to 400 works in one of the Egyptian antiquities libraries in the museum.
- A. British Museum
B. Louvre
C. Metropolitan Museum of Art
D. Smithsonian
7. On December 4th, Justice Samuel Alito ruled that it was “indisputable” that ____ motivation for redistricting was “pure and simple” partisan advantage, which the court has previously ruled is permissible. The state’s new map is designed to give the GOP control of 30 of the state’s 38 congressional districts.
- A. Texas’s
B. Missouri’s
C. California’s
D. North Carolina’s
8. Elon Musk won a shareholder vote that would give the Tesla CEO stock possibly worth \$1 trillion if he hits certain performance targets over the next decade, but it won’t be easy. One of the requirements is for Musk to grow Tesla’s ____, which he has promised will transform work and home, from zero to 1 million.
- A. wearable tech products
B. Starlink data centers
C. human-like robots
D. Grok subscribers
9. “The Federal Government was preparing to ‘surge’ ____, on Saturday, but friends of mine who live in the area called last night to ask me not to go forward with the surge in that the Mayor, Daniel Lurie, was making substantial progress,” Trump said on Truth Social in late October. He added the “friends” included the CEO of Nvidia and the CEO of Salesforce.
- A. Seattle, Washington
B. Washington D.C.
C. San Francisco, California
D. Austin, Texas

10. _____ announced it will eliminate synthetic dyes from all its private-label brand food products. Those brands include Marketside, Bettergoods, and Great Value, which is the nation’s largest consumer packaged goods brand. It also pledged to eliminate 30 other ingredients, including certain preservatives, artificial sweeteners, and fat substitutes.
- A. Whole Foods
B. Kroger
- C. Target
D. Walmart
11. After carving out a high-profile role as one of President Trump’s most vocal allies in the “Make America Great Again” movement, _____ had an acrimonious public split after weeks of speaking out against the president. Trump called the Representative a “lunatic” and “traitor,” and withdrew his endorsement. She later announced she would resign from Congress.
- A. Lauren Boebert
B. Laura Loomer
- C. Anna Paulina Luna
D. Marjorie Taylor Greene
12. The University of _____ removed an instructor who was accused by a student of religious discrimination over a failing grade on a psychology paper in which she cited the Bible and argued that promoting a “belief in multiple genders” was “demonic.”
- A. Texas A&M
B. Florida
- C. Oklahoma
D. Nebraska
13. In early February, U.S. Attorney Jeanine Pirro failed to gain an indictment when no grand jurors found that the Justice Department had reached the low probable cause threshold needed to indict _____ and other members of Congress after they released a video telling military members, “You can refuse illegal orders.”
- A. Ted Lieu
B. Hakeem Jefferies
- C. Tammy Duckworth
D. Mark Kelly
14. The UAE announced a withdrawal of forces from _____ at the end of December. The announcement followed a Saudi-led air strike on a suspected weapons shipment for UAE-backed separatist forces. Saudi Arabia and the UAE have been allies in the nation’s civil war, but the infighting between the rival factions they support has deepened a rift between them.
- A. Syria
B. Yemen
- C. Palestine
D. Lebanon

15. New _____ News Editor-in-Chief Bari Weiss said she will make the news division "fit for purpose in the 21st Century" and that changes are needed due to the public's lack of trust in mainstream media. Her changes have been met with pushback from some at the network who have resigned or taken buyouts.
- A. ABC
B. CBS
C. CNN
D. NBC
16. The first city in the U.S. to directly link wages to housing affordability will be _____ when its minimum wage will increase to \$17.50 starting in 2027. The annual increase historically has been tied to consumer prices, but going forward fair market rent data will be included.
- A. Austin, Texas
B. Portland, Oregon
C. Burlington, Vermont
D. Santa Fe, New Mexico
17. In early November, the Supreme Court declined to consider a challenge to its landmark 2015 decision recognizing a constitutional right to same-sex marriage. The announcement, which came with no comment from the justices, indicates there is not an appetite among the high court's conservative majority to revisit the case known as _____.
- A. *Dobb's v. Jackson Women's Health Organization*
B. *Ramos v. Louisiana*
C. *Obergefell v. Hodges*
D. *Gutter v. Bollinger*
18. _____ said Director-General Tim Davie and news CEO Deborah Turness had both decided to leave after the public broadcaster had been criticized for editing a speech President Trump made on January 6, 2021, before protesters attacked the Capitol in Washington.
- A. NPR
B. CNN
C. The BBC
D. PBS
19. Casey Wasserman's job as chairman of the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics organizing committee was announced as "safe" on February 11th, after the LA28 board's executive committee met to discuss a review conducted with help from an outside legal firm about Wasserman's past _____.
- A. investments into land deals backed by IOC board members
B. interactions with Jeffrey Epstein and Ghislaine Maxwell
C. use of committee funds to host IOC members at luxury resorts
D. dismissal of sexual assault allegations by former athletes

20. It was reported in February that a statue of _____ was to be installed on the south lawn of the White House grounds. The piece is a reconstruction of a statue from Baltimore that was dumped in the city's harbor by protesters in 2020.
- A. Robert E. Lee
B. Andrew Jackson
- C. Roger B. Taney
D. Christopher Columbus
21. The Attorney General of _____, Johel Zelaya, asked Interpol to execute an arrest order for ex-President Juan Orlando Hernández, who was pardoned by U.S. President Donald Trump. Hernández had been sentenced in U.S. federal court last year to 45 years for trafficking cocaine.
- A. Ecuador
B. Peru
- C. Honduras
D. Colombia
22. For the first time, scientists in the journal *Nature Communications* identified four distinct turning points between phases of development at ages 9, 32, 66, and 83 in an average human's _____. They believe during each epoch between those years, there are markedly different characteristics in the architecture than at other times in a person's lifespan.
- A. personality
B. hormone production
- C. metabolic processes
D. brain
23. Mosquitoes have been discovered in _____ for the first time ending its distinction as one of the world's few mosquito-free places. Three *Culiseta annulata* mosquitoes were sighted around 20 miles north of the volcanic country's capital, according to an entomologist at the nation's Natural Science Institute.
- A. Mongolia
B. Iceland
- C. Japan
D. Greenland
24. Population growth in _____ slowed significantly last year amid a nationwide slowdown in the number of newcomers moving to the U.S., but still topped the rest of the country for adding new residents. U.S. Census Bureau data showed the state added 391,243 residents in 2025.
- A. Texas
B. Florida
- C. California
D. Arizona

25. In early January, for only the second time in the nearly 4-year-old war, Russia bombarded Ukraine using a powerful, new _____ and nuclear-capable missile. The intense barrage and the launch of the Oreshnik missile was condemned by European leaders as “escalatory and unacceptable.”
- A. space-based
B. remotely piloted
C. hypersonic
D. bunker-busting
26. After more than two centuries in print, _____ ended its run with its 2026 edition. Known for long-term weather predictions, moon phases, fishing guides, and folk wisdom, the publication leaves a 208-year legacy.
- A. *Farmers’ Almanac*
B. *The Old Farmer’s Almanac*
C. *Poor Richard’s Almanack*
D. *World Almanac and Book of Facts*
27. In late December, protests in Iran were sparked by the _____ and quickly spread across the country. They were met by a violent crackdown by Iran’s theocracy and the country faced more than two weeks of internet blackout — the most comprehensive in its history. The bloody crackdown on nationwide protests killed at least 6,221.
- A. fall of the Iranian currency, the rial,
B. beating of a woman for removing her hijab
C. visit of former crown-prince, Reza Pahlavi,
D. burning of a Koran in nearby India
28. Texas Governor Greg Abbott designated _____, one of the largest Muslim advocacy groups in the U.S., a “foreign terrorist organization.” He accused it of attempting to “subvert our laws through violence, intimidation, and harassment.” Abbott said the designation would bar the organization from buying land and clear the way for the attorney general “to shut them down.”
- A. the Council on American-Islamic Relations
B. the Muslim Public Affairs Council
C. Emgage
D. Muslims for Just Futures
29. The company responsible for making the first GLP-1 weight-loss pill available this year, _____, said it was suing Hims & Hers Health Inc. for making knock-offs of its obesity medicines, even as Hims scrapped plans to sell a copycat version of the Wegovy pill.
- A. Eli Lilly
B. AstraZeneca
C. Novo Nordisk
D. Pfizer

30. Congress established the independence of _____ in the 1990s after instances of military leadership getting involved in editorial decisions. In January, the Pentagon announced new changes to the independent military newspaper so it concentrates on “reporting for our warfighters” and no longer includes “woke distractions.”
- A. *Stars and Stripes* C. *Armed Forces Weekly*
B. *All Hands* D. *Order of the Day*
31. The 10-day closure of the airspace over _____ was announced unexpectedly before ending hours later causing confusion and leading the mayor to claim that the chaos "was completely unnecessary". It was later reported that the closure followed a test where an energy laser was used to shoot down what appeared to be a foreign drone, but was actually a party balloon.
- A. Detroit, Michigan C. Jacksonville, Florida
B. El Paso, Texas D. Buffalo, New York
32. Thailand and _____ agreed in late December to halt the worst fighting in years between the countries. The fighting, that included fighter-jet sorties, exchange of rocket fire, and artillery barrages, killed at least 101 people and displaced more than half a million. The border dispute had re-ignited after a ceasefire brokered by the U.S. and Malaysia broke down.
- A. Vietnam C. Myanmar
B. Cambodia D. Laos
33. *Time* Magazine's Person of the Year for 2025 was not a single person. Instead, the magazine recognized the year's most influential figure as _____.
- A. "the architects" of AI C. peacemakers around the world
B. social media “influencers” D. the people of Ukraine
34. The arrival of Israel’s president in Australia to mourn the deaths of 15 people shot at a Hanukkah celebration at _____ set off protests and clashes between police and activists who had objected to his invitation from Australia’s Prime Minister. The Jewish Council of Australia said his presence “would fuel the flames of division” in the country.
- A. Canberra’s Parliament House C. Bondi Beach
B. Cape Kimberley D. Melbourne City Hall

35. As part of the spending deal to end the government shutdown in November, federal lawmakers approved a provision banning the _____. The provision was added at the last minute to a bill that provided yearlong funding for the Department of Agriculture. It closed what proponents of the ban call a “loophole” from the 2018 farm bill.
- A. sale of hemp-derived products
 - B. subsidizing of minority owned farms
 - C. export of U.S. soybeans to China
 - D. diversion of well water for non-agricultural use
36. Former _____ president Sepp Blatter backed a proposed fan boycott of World Cup matches in the U.S. because of the conduct of the current administration. Blatter, who is no stranger to controversy, was the latest international figure to call into question the suitability of the U.S. as a host country.
- A. International Olympic Committee (IOC)
 - B. U.N. Human Rights Council (HRC)
 - C. Court of Arbitration for Sport (CAS)
 - D. Fédération Internationale de Football Association (FIFA)
37. Over three years, the U.S. Citizens Coinage Advisory Committee settled on coins to celebrate the 250th anniversary of America’s founding, but when the Treasury Department revealed the new coins they did not include the Committee’s proposed images of Frederick Douglas, Ruby Bridges, or the _____.
- A. Emancipation Proclamation
 - B. March on Washington
 - C. Bill of Rights
 - D. Women’s Suffrage Movement
38. The Pentagon announced in early February that it was sending about 200 troops to _____ to help train its military to fight Islamist militants, weeks after President Trump criticized the country for failing to shield Christians from terrorist attacks. This follows Christmas Day missile strikes by the U.S. on alleged terrorist targets in the African nation.
- A. South Africa
 - B. Rwanda
 - C. Nigeria
 - D. Somalia
39. The _____ Senate, where 40 of 50 members are Republican, voted 31 to 19 against congressional redistricting. The result came after several anonymous threats against lawmakers including a swatting call to Senator Greg Goode who was undecided at the time.
- A. Virginia
 - B. Indiana
 - C. Georgia
 - D. Michigan

40. The song “Walk My Walk” by country group Breaking Rust reached No. 1 on Billboard’s Country Digital Song Sales chart in November, beating out Cain Walker, who also had two songs in the top 10. Both artists have made news recently for ____.
- A. opposing Bad Bunny’s Super Bowl performance
 - B. refusing to perform in Minneapolis or Chicago
 - C. lip syncing live performances
 - D. being AI-generated musicians

ESSAY PROMPT:

NOTE: Contestants who do not write an essay will be disqualified. Any essay that does not demonstrate a sincere effort to discuss the assigned topic will be disqualified. The rankings of essays will be based primarily on how well the topic has been addressed. A focused, concise and specific essay beats a vague and rambling essay. Proper grammar and organization should be used to aid clarity, but should not be considered a major factor in scoring. Cover as many corners of the issue as practical. Avoid including personal editorialized opinions, as more than enough information on the subject has been published.

Prime Minister Pedro Sánchez of Spain...announced plans to bar anyone under the age of 16 from accessing social media, the latest in a global push to shield children from potential harm caused by online platforms. “We will protect them from the digital wild west.”

Mr. Sánchez said the ban...includes an effort to make company executives legally responsible if illegal or hate-related content is not removed from their platforms, and to criminalize the manipulation of algorithms and the amplification of illegal content.

The goal is to reassert democratic control over social media, Mr. Sánchez said, and to rein in major digital platforms “where laws are ignored, and crimes are tolerated.”

Mr. Sánchez’s announcements echoed growing worries around the world about the impact of social media on children...”

-José Bautista reporting for The New York Times, February 3, 2026

Individuals, organizations, and countries around the world have begun to push back against the reach, influence, and possible detrimental impact of social media, online platforms, and chatbots. These efforts are playing out in schools, courtrooms, and legislative houses with varying degrees of success. Discuss recent significant individual and collective efforts around the world and in the U.S. to protect people, especially minors, from the dangers of unchecked online technology.

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 DISTRICT • 2026
ANSWER KEY

(2 points each)

- | | |
|-------|-------|
| 1. B | 21. C |
| 2. C | 22. D |
| 3. D | 23. B |
| 4. A | 24. A |
| 5. C | 25. C |
| 6. B | 26. A |
| 7. A | 27. A |
| 8. C | 28. A |
| 9. C | 29. C |
| 10. D | 30. A |
| 11. D | 31. B |
| 12. C | 32. B |
| 13. D | 33. A |
| 14. B | 34. C |
| 15. B | 35. A |
| 16. D | 36. D |
| 17. C | 37. D |
| 18. C | 38. C |
| 19. B | 39. B |
| 20. D | 40. D |

Points contestants could mention in their essay:

National Bans and Inquiries

- Australia's ban on social media for those under age 16 took effect on Dec. 10. It put the onus on Instagram and others to restrict users or face fines up to \$49.5 million AUD. In January, regulators said that companies had "removed access" to about 4.7 million accounts belonging to children under 16.
- France's lower house passed a ban in Jan. (age 15) and the UK is considering laws with limits on social media and uses of AI chatbots.
- Spain, Austria, Greece, Malaysia, New Zealand, and Indonesia have all announced plans for a ban for those under 14-16 years of age.
- Countries such as Denmark, Portugal, and Brazil have plans for parental consent requirements for use by those under age 16.
- The European Commission launched an investigation into Elon Musk's X in Jan. over the production of sexually explicit images and the spreading of possible child sexual abuse material by the platform's AI chatbot, Grok. It also extends an investigation into X's algorithms that help users discover new content.

Lawsuits

- Character.AI and Google settled lawsuits in FL, CO, NY, and TX over claims of negligence by the companies leading to self-harm or death. CA and NY have added regulations for chatbots directed at protection young users.
- Discord added age verification in March after it was linked to sexual exploitation lawsuits against Roblox for creating an unsafe online environment.

•Parents in CA and TX have sued OpenAI/ChatGPT for encouraging their children to commit suicide.

•In Feb. a "test case" in CA accused Meta/Instagram and Google/YouTube of deliberately trying to addict children and causing them harm. TikTok and Snap Inc. settled similar allegations for undisclosed sums before the trial began. Mark Zuckerberg and other CEOs testified and internal documents have compared the industry and case to Big Tobacco in the 1990s.

•A Feb. case in NM accuses Meta of using its algorithms to push harmful material.

U.S. Legislation

•There have been discussions of a ban in the U.S. for younger users, but free-speech challenges have slowed any progress and most limits have been left to individual states.

•Nebraska's law that require parental consent for users under 18 set to go into effect this year. Virginia has a new one hour a day limit for those under 16 unless given parental consent.

•Congress voted to ban TikTok in the U.S. starting Jan. 2025 due to national security concerns. The ban was delayed until Jan. 2026 when the Chinese-based ByteDance created a US-owned version of the platform

•HB 1481 in TX required a ban on all personal communication devices in schools starting towards the beginning of the 2025-26 school year. The stated goals were to reduce distractions and to limit cyberbullying. Nearly 40 states have some restrictions on phones with 18 having bell-to-bell bans and others looking to extend existing limits.